Contact

www.linkedin.com/in/christopher-kirchhoff (LinkedIn)

Top Skills

Public Policy
technology policy
Strategic Planning

Honors-Awards

Secretary of Defense Medal for Outstanding Public Service
Civilian Service Medal for Hazardous Missions in Iraq
High School Heisman Award for top U.S. prep scholar athlete

Christopher Kirchhoff, Ph.D.

Scale AI
San Francisco, California, United States

Summary

Christopher Kirchhoff is an expert in emerging technology who founded the Pentagon's Silicon Valley office and has led teams for the President, Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and CEO of Google. He recently worked special projects at Anthropic. Previously, Dr. Kirchhoff helped scale $1 billion in philanthropic programs at Schmidt Futures. He also founded and led the Pentagon's Silicon Valley Office, Defense Innovation Unit X, which piloted flying cars and microsatellites in military missions and created a new acquisition pathway for start-ups now responsible for $70 billion dollars of technology acquisition. During the Obama Administration, he was Director for Strategic Planning at the National Security Council and the senior civilian advisor to the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Together with Raj Shah, he is the author of Unit X: How the Pentagon and Silicon Valley are Transforming the Future of War.

Experience

Scale AI
Head of Applied AI Strategy and Global Security
August 2025 - Present (1 year)
San Francisco, California, United States

Aeolus Labs
Advisor
April 2025 - Present (1 year 4 months)

Muon Space
Board of Advisors
2023 - Present (3 years)

Special Competitive Studies Project - SCSP
Advisor
2022 - Present (4 years)

Launched by Eric Schmidt and Henry Kissinger to enhance U.S. competitiveness.

Defense Innovation Unit (DIU)
Advisor
November 2023 - October 2025 (2 years)

Anthropic
Special Projects Policy Residency
April 2024 - June 2024 (3 months)
San Francisco, California, United States

California 100 Initiative
Advisory Board Member
2022 - 2023 (1 year)

An initiative by Evan Spiegel to image California's next century.

National Security Commission on Artificial Intelligence
Special Government Employee
2019 - 2021 (2 years)

Devised industrial policy for the U.S. to be globally competitive in the age of A.I.

Schmidt Futures
Senior Director & Senior Fellow
2018 - 2021 (3 years)
New York City and San Francisco

Part of the founding team that designed and scaled $1 billion in philanthropic programs at Schmidt Futures and grew the philanthropy of Google CEO Eric Schmidt from 10 to 100 people. Led programs and grant-making in technology and society, including initiatives on AI for social good, the ethics of invention and innovation, and technology for underserved populations. With Eric Schmidt, co-directed initiatives on China, COVID, and technological competition. With Barbara Bush, led a 23-nation study of COVID by 78 researchers across 47 institutions debuted at Futures Forum on Preparedness with the WHO Director-General and Anthony Fauci.

Institute of Politics at Harvard Kennedy School
Visiting Technologist
2018 - 2018 (less than a year)
Cambridge, Massachusetts, United States

Taught undergraduate study group on “Public Leadership in a Technological Age”

Defense Innovation Unit (DIU)
Founding Partner
May 2016 - November 2017 (1 year 7 months)
Silicon Valley

Appointed by the Secretary of Defense to create and launch the Pentagon's Silicon Valley Office. Led staff of 67 civilian and uniformed personnel overseeing over 100 projects piloting advanced commercial technology¬—from flying cars to microsatellites—in military missions. Fielded capabilities now used by in combat and humanitarian missions worldwide, from air operations software that prevented ISIS from committing genocide to space-based SAR imaging to detect North Korean and Russian missile launches. Revitalized relations between the Pentagon, start-ups, and the venture capital community by pioneering a rapid acquisition pathway now responsible for $39 billion dollars of technology acquisition by the Department of Defense.

National Security Council, The White House
1 year

Director for Strategic Planning
2015 - 2016 (1 year)
Washington, DC

NSC’s lead strategist on technology. Led the NSC’s 15-person Strategic Planning Small Group, which advises the President and National Security Advisor on strategic trends in technology, security, economics, and geopolitics. With U.S. Chief Technology Officer Megan Smith, led 23-person study on the future of technology.

White House Ebola Task Force
2015 - 2015 (less than a year)
Washington, DC

Under “Ebola Czar” Ron Klain, oversaw Operation United Assistance, which deployed 3,000 U.S. troops in support of 100,000 health care workers to end the Ebola epidemic in West Africa. Led 74-person NSC Lessons Learned Study on Ebola credited with presaging the COVID pandemic.

The White House
Senior Advisor to the Counselor to the President
2014 - 2014 (less than a year)

Served in the Cheif of Staff's office. Primary Author, White House Report on Big Data under Counselor to the President John Podesta.

Department of Defense

5 years

Special Assistant to the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff

2011 - 2014 (3 years)

Pentagon

Led 8-person Initiatives Team on the Joint Staff which prepared the Chairman for all meetings with the President and Secretary of Defense. Helped develop the military's strategies on cyber, technology, innovation, Ebola, operational energy, and the future of war. Chairman's liaison to Silicon Valley and DARPA.

Special Advisor to the Deputy Secretary of Defense

2009 - 2011 (2 years)

Pentagon

Accompanied William Lynn, the Pentagon's #2 civilian official, on over twenty trips around the world. Staff author of landmark Foreign Affairs article, "Defending a New Domain: Pentagon's Cyber Strategy." Helped oversee the creation of DoD strategies on cyber, space, climate, and operational energy

Special Inspector General for Iraq Reconstruction

Lead Writer, Hard Lessons: The Iraq Reconstruction Experience

2006 - 2009 (3 years)

Washington, D.C. and Baghdad, Iraq

Co-author of 28-chapter official history coined "the Iraq Pentagon Papers" by The New York Times. Embedded in military and foreign aid operations across Iraq, Kuwait, and Jordan during the surge. Civilian Service Medal for hazardous missions in Iraq.

Space Shuttle Columbia Accident Investigation Board

Editor, Final Report

2003 - 2003 (less than a year)

Houston, Texas and Washington, DC

Explored the accident's "organizational cause" on team led by sociologist Diane Vaughan. Authored report findings and recommendations on NASA organizational failures, "broken safety culture," shuttle program history, and national space policy.

Education

Cambridge University

Ph.D., Social & Political Sciences · (2010)

University of Cambridge

Master of Philosophy (M.Phil.), Social and Political Science · (2001 - 2002)

Harvard University

A.B., History and Science · (1997 - 2001)